

Northwind Traders

Employee Handbook & Policy Guide — Edition 2026.1 · Document ID: NWT-HB-2026-01 · Effective 1 April 2026

This handbook is fictional sample content created for training and demonstration only.

This guide summarises the core people, expense, and IT-security policies for all Northwind Traders employees. Where a policy conflicts with a signed employment contract, the contract prevails. Questions about any section should go to the People Operations team.

1. Working Hours & Remote Work

Standard working hours are 9:00 AM to 5:30 PM, Monday to Friday, with a one-hour unpaid lunch break. The core collaboration window, during which all employees must be reachable, is 11:00 AM to 3:00 PM in their local time zone. Employees may work from home up to **three days per week**; any fully-remote arrangement requires written approval from the employee's line manager and the People Operations team. New joiners serve a probation period of **90 days**, during which either party may end the employment with two weeks' notice.

2. Leave & Time Off

Leave entitlements are granted per calendar year and reset on 1 January. Unused annual leave of up to five days may be carried into the following year.

Leave type	Entitlement	Notes
Annual leave	24 days / year	Accrues monthly; max 5 days carry-over
Sick leave	12 days / year	Medical certificate required after 3 consecutive days
Parental leave	26 weeks	Paid at 100% for the first 12 weeks
Bereavement leave	5 days	Per immediate-family event
Volunteer day	2 days / year	For approved community activities

3. Expense & Reimbursement Policy

Employees must submit expense claims through the Northwind Expense Portal within **30 days** of the expense being incurred. Every claim requires an itemised receipt. Claims are approved by the employee's line manager and reimbursed with the next payroll run. The daily limits below are the maximum reimbursable amounts unless pre-approved in writing by a department head.

Category	Limit	Conditions
Meals (per day)	USD 75	Covers breakfast, lunch, and dinner combined while travelling
Hotel (per night)	USD 220	Standard room; higher rates need department-head approval
Ground transport	USD 60 / day	Taxi, rideshare, or public transit; keep receipts

Category	Limit	Conditions
Mileage (own car)	USD 0.62 / mile	Log start and end odometer readings
Client entertainment	USD 150 / event	Must list attendees and business purpose

Non-reimbursable items include personal entertainment, traffic fines, in-room minibar purchases, and travel upgrades bought without prior approval.

4. IT & Information-Security Policy

All employees are responsible for protecting Northwind Traders systems and data. Account passwords must be at least **14 characters**, contain a mix of upper- and lower-case letters, numbers, and symbols, and be changed every **90 days**. Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory on all company accounts. Passwords must never be shared or reused across services.

A lost or stolen device — laptop, phone, or security key — must be reported to the IT Service Desk within **one hour** of discovery so the device can be remotely locked and wiped. Do not attempt to recover the device yourself. Suspected phishing emails should be forwarded to phishing@northwind.example and then deleted.

Company data classified as Confidential or Restricted may only be stored on approved, encrypted company systems. Storing such data on personal cloud drives or USB media is prohibited. Software may only be installed from the approved Northwind Software Catalog.

Security rule	Requirement
Minimum password length	14 characters
Password rotation	Every 90 days
Multi-factor authentication	Required on all accounts
Lost/stolen device reporting	Within 1 hour to IT Service Desk
Screen auto-lock	After 10 minutes of inactivity
Approved data storage	Encrypted company systems only

5. Who to Contact

Need	Team	Contact
Lost or stolen device, account lockout, software requests	IT Service Desk	ext. 4357 · itdesk@northwind.example
Leave, payroll, benefits, contracts	People Operations	ext. 2200 · people@northwind.example
Expense claims and approvals	Finance	ext. 3100 · finance@northwind.example
Suspected phishing or security incident	Security Operations	ext. 9110 · phishing@northwind.example

End of document · Northwind Traders is a fictional company. All names, contacts, and figures are illustrative sample data for AI knowledge-base testing.